

Data breaches and death threats

THE 23RD OF OCTOBER TURNED OUT TO BE A RATHER WEIRD DAY FOR ME.

I woke up to my phone pinging notifications at me, which is odd, because I usually turn off all notifications from social media accounts and chat software. The only thing that gets priority notification access is my bank account. The first ping had jarred me awake at 6 am, the second ping made me wonder what was happening, and then a quick succession of 3 more pings made my mind up for me, and I reached out for my phone. As it turns out, my account was being emptied out with large purchases all happening in quick succession, using my wife's debit card. But how could that be, because she was lying right next to me fast asleep?

By the time I shook her awake I heard two more pings from my phone, and that was it, my account was officially empty except for maybe a few hundred dollars. We checked her wallet and found the card that was supposedly used, we called the bank and blocked the card and reported the fraud as well. We were assured that the money would be returned to us after investigation.

I immediately had her sit down and change all of her passwords, and found that she was using some weak passwords on some sites where her card information was stored, but still, there's no way the person should have got the full card number, CVV and expiry date from a hacked account. As users, we're not shown our own card number in full on all sites even after logging in, just the last 4 digits. It was obvious that a data breach had occurred from one of the sites she had bought something on. Still, passwords were changed, where possible two factor authentication was added, and a full security check completed, and much embarrassment braced for, as I would no doubt be ragged by my colleagues for allowing a security breach to happen within my family due to improper security. The only thing more embarrassing would be if Paranoid Android got scammed.

Onwards we went with our respective days, and the incident was almost forgotten. Then at 3 pm my wife received a call from what was obviously a teenager, asking to speak to my 7-year old, non-verbal, autistic son. That raised alarm bells immediately for her and she came running to give me the phone. When I got on the line, the teenager started to thank me for buying him new shoes and other things (he thought I

was my son, which meant he obviously didn't know my son's age). Knowing that it was the same scamster who had got a hold of my wife's card information, I informed him that the police had been informed, at which point he decided to force a maniacal laugh (it was very fake) and screamed that he would place a bomb in my home (he recited my home address) and would kill me and my family. Then he hung up before I could laugh back in his face!

sigh Kids!

So loud was his threat though, that my wife heard it over the ear piece, and now she was terrified. She already blamed herself for causing the security breach, and was now afraid that someone would come over and harm our son, who the caller had asked for. That was information he'd obviously got from one of her government accounts.

Now I find myself calling the police, who take mention of the word "bomb" very seriously here, and my entire afternoon is ruined because a silly script kiddie who bought some credit card information from an actual hacker, decided to have some fun and crank call his victim.

Of course the police eventually arrived at the same conclusion as me, and said it was very unlikely that the person in question is even in the same state as me here in Australia, and the likelihood of someone having a bomb in Australia is pretty much zero. So I got the run-around, with my local police telling me to make a cyber crime report, which I did. Only to get a response a few days later saying that they could not do anything and I would need to make a local police report for the threat to life... The authorities everywhere are the same I guess, too busy with more important stuff to care about than the 2500 dollars that were stolen from my home expense account, which the bank would return in 15 days anyway, thanks to insurance...

We ended the day sitting around laughing and telling everyone who called about the incident. If nothing else, we have a story to tell people, and give everyone a reminder about not being complacent and using weak passwords anywhere. Use this anecdote as a reminder to check and re-secure all of your accounts, and set up two factor authentication wherever possible. And please, don't use the same password on multiple sites. 🇺🇸



"*sigh* Kids!"



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